

Roosting

These turkey buzzards from North America have gathered in a tree to roost, or settle for the night. Many vultures roost high in trees or on rocky ledges, because this makes it easier for them to take off and become airborne when the day begins.



Vulture guards carrion while companion eats.

Long neck enables the vulture to reach into a carcass.



Vultures feeding on carrion

White-backed vulture

With a wingspan of more than 2.5 m (8 ft), this huge vulture soars high over open country in southern Europe, Asia, and Africa. Like most other vultures, it has a bare head and neck. If it had long feathers, they would become soaked with blood when it feeds, as it tears the meat from inside a carcass with its beak.

Bare head and neck for ease of cleaning

**Carrion eaters**

Instead of hunting live animals, vultures feed on the remains of ones that are already dead, carrion. Vultures live in open places, such as deserts, grasslands, and mountains, and find their food by soaring and looking for animal carcasses from the air. Vultures have large beaks, but their talons are weak.

Feeding

Vultures have keen eyesight. If one vulture spots a carcass, and drops down to feed, others quickly follow. Soon vultures arrive from all around. The largest and most dominant species feed first, leaving the smaller species to fight over the scraps.

Specialist eaters

During millions of years of evolution, some birds of prey have developed highly specialized diets as well as specific techniques to deal with their food. Most of these specialist feeders eat animal food, but a few are vegetarians. Some species of bird have learned to live alongside humans, particularly in urban environments, and they eat the variety of food scraps that people throw away.



Egyptian vulture

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The Egyptian vulture is one of only a few birds that uses tools to obtain food. It eats ostrich eggs, which it breaks open by picking up stones and hurling them against the shell until it breaks. As well as in Egypt, it lives in other parts of Africa, Europe, and Asia.

Secretary bird

Eyes face to the side instead of the front.

Slim, athletic build for hunting on the ground in open country

Feathery quills, like those once used for writing, give the secretary bird its name.

Brightly coloured face

Secretary bird raises its crest of black feathers to attract a mate.

Tough scales protect the legs from poisonous snake bites.



Lightly built with long wings

Long tail feathers provide balance.



Snail kite

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The snail kite lives in marshy places from the southern USA to Argentina in South America. It feeds almost entirely on freshwater snails, which it snatches from the water with one of its feet. It then hooks out the snail's body with its long slender beak.

Palm-nut vulture

The diet of this African vulture is based mainly on the fruits of oil palms, but it eats some small animals. Unlike other vultures, it does not have to fly long distances in search of food, and spends most of its time in trees.

**Secretary bird**

This highly unusual bird of prey from Africa hunts on the ground. It has long strong legs, and kills animals by stamping them to death. The secretary bird often feeds on snakes, and when attacking uses its wings like a shield to protect itself.

**Largest and smallest**

The Andean condor is the largest bird of prey, with a wingspan of more than 3 m (10 ft). It is a carrion eater. The smallest birds of prey are pygmy falcons and falconets, which feed mainly on flying insects. Some are only 15 cm (6 in) long.

LANNER FALCON

SCIENTIFIC NAME *Falco biarmicus*

ORDER Falconiformes

FAMILY Falconidae

DISTRIBUTION Southern Europe, Africa, and the Middle East

HABITAT Scrub and desert

DIET Birds, small mammals, and lizards

SIZE Length, including tail: male – 37 cm (14.5 in); female – 47 cm (18.5 in)

LIFESPAN About 10 years

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